Chimp warfare

A shocking revelation that came out of the Gombe camp was that chimps are capable of violence, murder, and in particular warfare—once thought to be the preserve of humans. Between 1974 and 1978, Jane Goodall watched as her peaceful community of chimps fractured into two rival groups that then waged savage war on each other. Goodall was deeply upset about the chimps' activity, which included ambushes, kidnappings, and bloody murder. The trigger for the war was unclear; some researchers blamed the feeding stations Goodall had set up in the area, which may have encouraged unnatural congregations of chimps. The answer to the mystery came in March 2018, when a research team at Duke and Arizona State Universities, US, digitized Goodall's meticulous check sheets and field notes from 1967 to 1972 and fed them into a computer in order to analyze the social networks and alliances of all the male chimps. Their findings revealed that the fracture in the community occurred two years before the war broke out, when an alpha male Goodall called Humphrey took over the troupe, alienating two other high-ranking males called Charlie and Hugh and causing them to split off with some other chimps to the south. The two groups became more and more separate, feeding in different parts of the forest. At first there was the odd aggressive skirmish and then war broke out. Over four years, Humphrey and his cohorts killed every male in the southern group and took over their territory, as well as three surviving females. It is thought that the full-blown war may have been due to a lack of mature females in the northern group. Power struggles and fighting over a female all sound very human.

"I'm determined my great grandchildren will be able to go to Africa and find wild great apes."

Jane Goodall